
AFP

been marked by several legislative and administrative actions that could be perceived as against the state's Muslim population. On August 22, the government introduced the Assam Repealing Bill, 2024, in the assembly to abolish the Assam Moslem Marriages and Divorces Registration Act, 1935. Sarma has stated that a new bill will be introduced to mandate government registration of marriages and divorces for Muslims, a move viewed as a precursor to implementing the Uniform Civil Code in the state.

Last year, when the state government launched a campaign against child marriages, critics contended that the initiative was more about demonising a particular community than protecting children. Sarma defended the drive by pointing out that the arrests were evenly distributed among Muslims and Hindus. In fact, Assam's stringent legal measures proved effective, resulting in an 81 per cent decline in child marriage cases across 20 districts between 2021-22 and 2023-24, according to an India Child Protection (ICP) report. "The NFHS 5 (National Family Health Survey) data shows that the problem is most severe in Dhubri and South Salmara, not in Dibrugarh and Tinsukia," Sarma said. Dhubri and South Salmara are Muslim-majority districts, while Dibrugarh and Tinsukia have minimal Muslim presence. Similarly, his government's conversion of state-run madrassas into general education schools, and its eviction drives, which often affect immigrant Muslims, have also drawn criticism.

The polarisation that Sarma is fostering is not without an eye on the politics of the state. The recent Lok Sabha election revealed a significant shift: the state's Muslim population, which constitutes nearly 34 per cent of the total, has increasingly rallied around the Congress party. This shift has become more pronounced following the decline of the All India United Democratic Front, which previously held considerable sway among Assam's Muslims. Sarma is keen to frame this trend as an existential threat to the Hindu majority. He argues, "After the Lok Sabha election, in the areas where a party increased its vote share, the supporters of that party, which is a particular community, have become so emboldened that they are trying to establish their dominance. The atrocities being faced by Hindu women are a consequence of this." Notably, Nagaon has elected a Congress MP for a second consecutive term.

With Muslims holding considerable influence in 30 of Assam's 126 assembly constituencies, the BJP does face a formidable challenge. If the Congress secures a majority in these seats in the next assembly polls, it could drastically affect the BJP's prospects. For Sarma, this likelihood is deeply troubling. The recent victory of the Congress's Gaurav Gogoi in Jorhat—a region with a substantial Ahom population—further underscores this challenge. The Ahoms, an indigenous community that once ruled Assam for 600 years, now exert considerable influence in about eight constituencies. The erosion of Ahom support, coupled with the consolidation of Muslim votes behind the Congress, could spell disaster for the BJP in the upcoming election.

Critics allege that Sarma is trying to exploit the Dhing incident to create a unified Hindu vote bank, encouraging indigenous communities to set aside their ethnic identities in favour of a broader Hindu one. In response to the Dhing rape, some 30 organisations, including the All Tai Ahom Students' Union, have launched a movement in Upper Assam districts demanding the expulsion of Miyas.

Not all are convinced that Sarma's polarising push will yield the desired outcome. "It seems that the CM is attempting to frame the rising social discontent in parts of Assam, the general 'anti-outsider' sentiment that thrives in such situations caused by unemployment, poverty, crimes and calamities, within the discourse of 'Hindutva'," says Kaustubh Kumar Deka, assistant professor of Political Science at Dibrugarh University. "While such projections might resonate nationally, whether they will garner sufficient support within Assam remains an open question."

As politics in Assam undergoes transformation, Sarma's focus on protecting Assamese culture and countering perceived immigration threats strikes a chord with the public. But it is a project fraught with danger. Framing issues within a Hindu civilisational identity may bring electoral advantage but the societal fissures it will create will have long-term consequences. ■

"WHY WILL PEOPLE FROM LOWER ASSAM GO TO UPPER ASSAM? SO THAT MIYA MUSLIMS CAN TAKE OVER ASSAM? WE WON'T LET IT HAPPEN... I WILL TAKE (SIDES), WHAT WILL YOU DO? THIS IS MY IDEOLOGY"

–HIMANTA BISWA SARMA, *CM, Assam, in the assembly, Aug. 27*